LEADERSHIP AND OPERATIONS

Why Does Every Quote Still Need the Owner?

Separate valuable judgment from the missing information and unclear authority that keep routine work returning to one person.

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An owner’s involvement in quoting can serve several purposes: deciding risk, protecting margin, resolving unusual specifications, supplying information, or giving permission. Those are different jobs. Before removing an approval, identify which job the owner is actually doing and what would make that decision possible elsewhere.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Identify the actual job the owner performs.
- Separate missing information, authority, risk, and habit.
- Review decision quality as well as approval volume.

How do you find out why quotes need owner approval?

Review a completed quote and identify the precise decision that returned to the owner, the information they used, and what their answer changed. Approval may protect an unusual commitment, supply missing knowledge, or compensate for unclear authority. The reason determines whether the business should delegate, document, or retain the decision.

“The owner has to approve it” describes a routing rule. It does not explain why that rule exists. The owner might have negotiated a supplier condition nobody else can see. They might be applying a discount boundary that has never been written down. Or the decision may involve commercial risk the business intentionally reserves for them.

Each finding leads to a different intervention. Removing the approval without distinguishing them can make the process faster and less controlled.

What are the main reasons routine quotes get escalated?

Quotes may return because information is missing, authority is unclear, risk is exceptional, priorities conflict, or approval has become habitual. Use the NATA Decision Ownership Record below to separate those causes. Support the classification with actual decisions rather than accepting the team’s first explanation as established fact.

Reason the work returns	Question to investigate
Missing information	Does the owner know something that belongs in an accessible record?
Unclear authority	Could another person decide within explicit boundaries?
Exceptional risk	What makes this case different from routine work?
Conflicting priorities	Who resolves the tradeoff and on what basis?
Habit	Does this approval still change the outcome?

Record evidence for the classification. A team’s first explanation may describe the most visible part of the problem rather than its cause.

How do you delegate quote approval with clear limits?

Specify the decision another person may make, the information they need, the boundaries that apply, and the conditions requiring escalation. Those limits should reflect the business’s commercial judgment. The recipient should be able to explain a routine case and an exception before the new authority becomes the normal route.

For example, a supplier may allow a sales lead to prepare routine quotes using a current price basis and defined exclusions, while reserving unusual credit or delivery commitments for another decision maker. The exact policy requires the company's own commercial judgment. The transferable lesson is to specify the decision boundary.

Ask the person receiving authority to work through a normal case and an exception. If they cannot explain when to escalate, the delegation remains ambiguous.

Which quoting decisions should remain with the owner?

Retain decisions that genuinely require the owner's judgment, such as unfamiliar risk or a significant tradeoff across the business. Remove avoidable retrieval and permission requests around them where possible. The aim is to make escalation meaningful, not to treat every reduction in senior involvement as an improvement.

The question is how to use senior attention well. A calendar filled with approvals says little about the value of those approvals.

How can you test delegation before removing an approval?

Ask the delegated person to record the decision they would make and its evidence, then compare it with the authorized decision. Examine reasons for disagreement before expanding authority. This reveals whether the gap concerns information, boundaries, or training while the existing review remains in place.

ASQ describes Five Whys as a way to investigate beneath symptoms. Here, questioning needs to be paired with actual decision records; a plausible explanation alone does not establish what caused the escalation.

How do you measure whether quoting delegation worked?

Compare routine escalations, their reasons, decision quality, corrections, and total preparation effort before and after the change. Include work transferred to other people. Fewer owner approvals are useful only if the team can make appropriate decisions without creating avoidable rework or losing control of unusual commitments.

A useful result is a clearer distinction between work that needs the owner's judgment and work that needed the business to make its knowledge or authority explicit. That distinction makes delegation easier to trust on both sides.

Frequently asked questions

Does reducing owner dependency mean removing every approval?

No. Some approvals reflect deliberate commercial judgment. Investigate why each recurring escalation exists and retain those that protect decisions the business still wants the owner to make.

Should a delegation threshold copy another company's policy?

No. Set boundaries using the company's products, exposure, roles, and decision requirements. An arbitrary threshold can create permission without the knowledge or controls needed to use it.

What if the team still asks the owner after receiving authority?

Inspect an actual case. The person may lack a current record, confidence in a boundary, or a way to resolve an exception. Repeating that they are empowered does not establish which condition is missing.

SOURCES & CASE BASIS

This guide presents a working method, not measured client results. Examples are illustrative unless explicitly attributed. Sources linked in the text support the stated principle or published example; they do not validate the NATA worksheet as an assessed instrument. Prepared and revised November 4, 2026; unpublished editorial review draft.